

HIL RETURNS IN A NEW AVATAR



Cap's the word: Soormas HC was willing to break the bank for the Indian captain, Harmanpreet Singh. GETTY IMAGES

The auction for the new-look Hockey India League threw up some **interesting combinations**, with some teams looking stronger and better balanced, at least on paper.

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The seven-year itch proved too strong for the Hockey India League, but returning in a new avatar later this year, HIL 2.0 is set to be a completely different affair.

Scheduled to begin on December 28, it will feature new teams, new faces, new management, a revised format that restricts play to just two venues — at least for the first year — and the addition of a whole new women's league, making it an exciting watch from the moment its revival was officially announced.

While the excitement remains, the three days of auctions for men and women, along with certain issues surrounding them, have tempered it somewhat, adding a dose of realism to its hype of being the 'best hockey league in the world.'

A franchise withdrawing from the men's field, hastily replaced by another on the morning of the auction, the reduction of the women's field from six to four teams less than 24 hours prior, a modest purse of Rs. 4 crore for the men — half of that for the women — and concerns over the availability of overseas players, especially those who were acquired cheaply, around what is traditionally a holiday period, have been considered non-issues for the time being.

For now, all the teams insist they are happy with their combinations, though some undeniably appear stronger and better balanced, at least on paper. Here's how they stack up: